Coordination with and without incentives*

Pablo Brañas-Garza[†], Diego Jorrat[‡§] and Pablo Lomas[†]

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Abstract

This paper reports two studies ($n = 242$; $n = 301$) where participants played two coordination games: one with a payoff-dominant equilibrium and another with a risk-dominant equilibrium. Participants were randomly assigned to either monetary or hypothetical payment schemes. We examined both their strategic choices and the arguments supporting them. Results show no effect of the payment scheme: coordination rates and reasoning were similar across conditions.

Keywords: Hypothetical payoffs, Coordination games, Payoffs and Risk dominance.

JEL codes: C7, C99, D90

1 Introduction

While experimental economics traditionally assumes that paying monetary incentives to participants—conditional on their own and others' decisions—is strictly necessary (based on the idea that participants will pay more attention, make fewer "noisy" choices, etc.), an increasing number of studies challenge this view. Recent research shows that incentivized and hypothetical decisions often lead to similar outcomes—particularly in individual decision-making tasks such as temporal discounting (Brañas-Garza et al., 2023), decision-making under uncertainty (Brañas-Garza et al., 2021; Hackethal et al., 2023), and dictator games (Ben-Ner et al., 2008; Bühren and Kundt, 2015)—or report only minimal differences, even when comparing to high-stakes conditions (Enke et al., 2023). These findings—based on large samples and conducted both inside and outside the lab—suggest that monetary incentives may not always be essential for eliciting reliable behavior.

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[†] *LoyolaBehLab*, Universidad Loyola Andalucía.

[‡] Department of Applied Economics I, Universidad de Sevilla.

[§] Corresponding author. Email: dajorrat@gmail.com. Avda. Ramón y Cajal 1, 41018 Sevilla, Spain.

Evidence from games involving strategic interaction, however, remains scarce[1]. Locey et al. (2011) found no differences between real and hypothetical rewards in a temporal discounting game with the logic of a repeated prisoner's dilemma. Similarly, Amir et al. (2012) reported no differences in a trust game and in public goods games. Veselý (2015) observed virtually identical responses in incentivized and non-incentivized versions of the Krupka–Weber game, and König-Kersting (2024) replicated this result with a larger MTurk sample.

This paper studies the role of monetary incentives in $2x2$ coordination games. Subjects are asked to choose an action (A or B, for simplicity): if both players choose the same action (AA or BB), they receive a positive payoff; otherwise (AB or BA), the payoff is zero. Each subject plays two games: in the first, one equilibrium payoff-dominates the other; in the second, one equilibrium risk-dominates the other. In both cases, once subjects choose A or B, they are asked to select one of four explanations for their decision.

In Study 1 ($n = 242$), participants played the payoff-dominance game first and then the risk-dominance game. In Study 2 ($n = 301$), game order was randomized. In both studies, incentives—real or hypothetical—was randomized at the individual level with $p = 1/2$.

The results show that the use of real or hypothetical incentives has no effect on outcomes. This finding is important because, unlike previous studies that focused on individual decision-making, the lack of monetary incentives in strategic settings could theoretically affect not only whether a subject takes the task seriously but also whether they believe their counterpart will do so. Our results suggest that this is not the case.

Therefore, our findings are consistent with prior work questioning the necessity of monetary incentives and extend this line of research to environments involving strategic interaction.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows: the second section contains the design, implementation and outcomes variables of the experiment. Third section presents the main results, while fourth concludes.

2 Design, Implementation and Outcomes

2.1 Design

In both studies, participants faced two coordination games, both with two equilibria. The first game (Game 1 in Table 1) had a payoff-dominant equilibrium (AA), while the second game (Game 2 in Table 1) had a risk-dominant equilibrium (AA). As detailed in Section A1 (Instructions) of the Supplementary Material (SM), participants chose between two colored buttons rather than actions A and B. Button colors varied across games.

[1] The work of Blanco et al. (2010) is also relevant because it examines whether monetary incentives can promote hedging among participants.

Game 1

	A	B
A	**1, 1**	0, 0
B	0, 0	0.5, 0.5

Game 2

	A	B
A	**1, 1**	0.5, 0
B	0, 0.5	1, 1

Table 1: Game 1 and Game 2

One of the challenges with very simple decision problems (such as choosing between A or B) is that participants may select an option at random, making it difficult for us to interpret their choices. To address this issue, after making their decision in Game 1 (and before playing Game 2), we included a question asking them to explain why they had made that choice. They had to choose one of four options (presented in random order): *a*) Because I earned more, *b*) Because I earned less, *c*) Because I liked the color, or *d*) I chose randomly. Similarly, after making their decision in Game 2, they were also given four options to choose from: *a*) Because it was less risky, *b*) Because it was more risky, *c*) Because I liked the color, or *d*) I chose randomly.

2.2 Implementation

The experiments in both studies were conducted at Universidad Loyola Andalucía. Sessions for Study 1 were held in November 2023, whereas those for Study 2 took place between November and December 2024. In Study 1, participants faced the two games in a fixed sequence (Game 1 → Game 2). In Study 2, an additional layer of randomization was introduced: the order of the two games was randomized.

Participants in Study 1 ($n = 242$) were mostly A-level students visiting the university ($n_{A-level} = 137$) as part of an open day event, although some Loyola students also participated ($n_{Loyola} = 105$). Study 2 ($n = 301$), conducted almost identically one year later, included only Loyola students. Table 2 reports the sample distribution by academic level and gender for both studies.

Table 2: Participants by study, academic level and gender

	High School	University	All
Study 1			
Male	65	38	103
Female	72	66	138
Other	0	1	1
% Female	52.55	62.86	57.02
Total	137	105	242
Study 2			
Male	0	174	174
Female	0	125	125
Other	0	2	2
% Female	-	41.53	41.53
Total	0	301	301

The experiments were implemented using Qualtrics and conducted in designated classrooms, where participants read the instructions and made their decisions using their mobile phones.[2] The randomization to monetary vs. hypothetical incentives was done at the individual level. Table A1 in Appendix A presents the balance of participants' characteristics. As can be seen, randomization worked properly in both Study 1 and Study 2, as none of the individual characteristics differ significantly between the Monetary and Hypothetical groups. All p-values are well above conventional significance levels, and the joint orthogonality F-test confirm that the set of covariates does not differ across treatments.

Participants in both studies completed a second part of the experiment that consisted of two tasks: an affective Theory of Mind (ToM) task[3] and the Cognitive Reflection Test (CRT).[4] Only ToM task was incentivized for those who had been assigned to the hypothetical condition in the first part (the games). In other words, subjects can obtain a reward in the experiment through two ways: i) Their performance in Games 1 and 2, ii) Their number of correct answers in the ToM task. This design ensured that every participant had a chance to earn a reward, avoiding a situation in which some participants were paid while others were not. Average payments were €2.19 (Study 1) and €2.05 (Study 2) for sessions lasting under 10 minutes, including the €1 show-up fee.[5]

2.3 Outcomes

In Game 1, we say that a subject plays P if they choose the payoff-dominant strategy (= 0 otherwise). We say they play $PayD$ if, in addition to choosing the payoff-dominant strategy, they also select the justification "*Because I earned more*".

In Game 2, we say that a subject plays R if they choose the risk-dominant strategy (= 0 otherwise). We say they play $RiskD$ if, in addition to choosing the risk-dominant strategy, they also select the justification "*Because it was less risky*".

Obviously, both $PayD$ and $RiskD$ are subsets of P and R respectively, and do not include subjects who chose inconsistent justifications.

In addition, we include age, gender, and reflective thinking (CRT, measured by the number of reflective answers) as control variables in the regression analysis.[6]

[2] Guo et al. (2023) analyze whether behavior differs between playing games on computers versus on mobile phones. They study several games (including the Stag Hunt) and find differences only in the Ultimatum Game.

[3] The ToM task was measured using the Developmental Read the Mind in the Eyes Test designed by Alfonso Costillo et al. (2023). The task consists of 10 images of a child's eyes expressing different emotions, each accompanied by four possible answers, one of which best represents the depicted emotion. Figures A3 and A4 in the Supplementary Materials (Section A1) illustrate the items of the ToM task. Correct answers are shown in bold. The order of the items was randomized.

[4] The CRT follows the task introduced by Frederick (2005). The items used are shown in Figure A5 in the Supplementary Materials (Section A1). Reflective and intuitive answers are shown in parentheses. The order of the items was randomized.

[5] Study 1: In Game 1 59.5% of the participants coordinated in either (AA) or (BB); the same fraction achieved coordination in Game 2. Study 2: Coordination was achieved in 58.8% of the interactions in Game 1 and 52.8% in Game 2.

[6] We do not include ToM score as control because only participants in the hypothetical condition were incentivized for this task. As a result, ToM performance may partly reflect treatment-induced motivation rather than pre-existing ability, making it a potential "bad control" Angrist and Pischke (2009).However, Table A1 in Appendix A shows no significant differences in ToM scores across treatment conditions ($p > 0.20$) in either study.

3 Results

3.1 Study 1

Figure 1 plots the percentage of subjects who play P, $PayD$, R, and $RiskD$, by treatment—Monetary (M) vs. Hypothetical (H). Error bars show ±1 standard error of the proportion for each bar. Above the bars for each outcome we report the p-value from a two-sample test of equality of proportions comparing M and H. The red dashed line represents the random-choice probability: 50% for actions and 12.5% for action-argument combinations.

As shown in Figure 1, 80% of participants chose the payoff-dominant strategy (P), and 66% also selected the correct argument (PayD). These percentages are somewhat higher than those reported by Dal Bó and Fréchette (2018)—with average rates of 51–61% across different designs—or Jagau (2024), who reports 56%. The most plausible explanation is that the use of colored buttons facilitated coordination. Second, we observe that 59% chose the risk-dominant strategy (R), but this percentage drops to 36% when the argument is taken into account (RiskD). These figures are similar than those reported by Schmidt et al. (2003)—60% in one-shot settings and 30–50% in repeated settings.

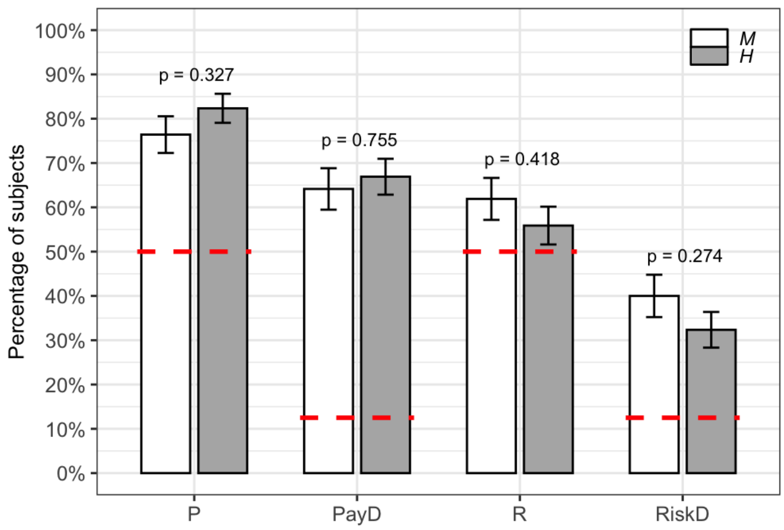

Figure 1: Study 1: Outcomes by incentive scheme. Error bars show ±1 standard error of the proportion for each bar.

Comparing proportions across M and H treatments, we find no statistically significant differences (all $p > 0.20$). Table A2 in Appendix B reports linear probability models, showing that the inclusion of controls leaves the results essentially unchanged. The coefficient on *hypothetical* is small and never statistically significant (all $p > 0.22$). Overall, *monetary and hypothetical incentives yield similar coordination rates.*

Two potential concerns with Study 1 relate to the experimental design and the sample composition. First, the order of the two games was fixed (Game 1 always preceded Game 2), which may have introduced order or learning effects if participants' choices in the second game were influenced by their experience in the first. Second, the sample included both university and A-level students, raising the possibility that age or educational differences might have affected behavior.

Study 2 addresses these issues by randomizing the order of the two games and focusing exclusively on university students.

3.2 Study 2

To address these concerns, we replicated the experiment with a new sample of 301 university students, this time randomizing the order of the two games. Figure 2 reports the same four outcomes as before, for both monetary and hypothetical incentives.

In this replication, 82% chose the payoff-dominant strategy (P) – 64% if the correct reasoning is considered ($PayD$) – and 63% the risk-dominant strategy (R) – 39% with correct explanation ($RiskD$). These figures are very close to those observed in Study 1.

Treatment comparisons again reveal small differences between M and H, which are generally not statistically significant ($p > 0.30$). Only ($PayD$) exhibits a marginally significant difference ($p = 0.09$) between M and H treatments; however, this effect vanishes once session fixed effects and controls are added, with the *hypothetical* coefficient no longer significant (see Table A3 in Appendix B; $p > 0.13$). Neither the order indicator ($G1$) nor its interaction with *hypothetical* is significant (all $p > 0.11$). Finally, Figure A1 in Appendix A splits the results by game order and confirms that none of the treatment differences are statistically significant (all $p > 0.18$).

Overall, Study 2 replicates Study 1, confirming that *monetary incentives have no meaningful impact on coordination.*

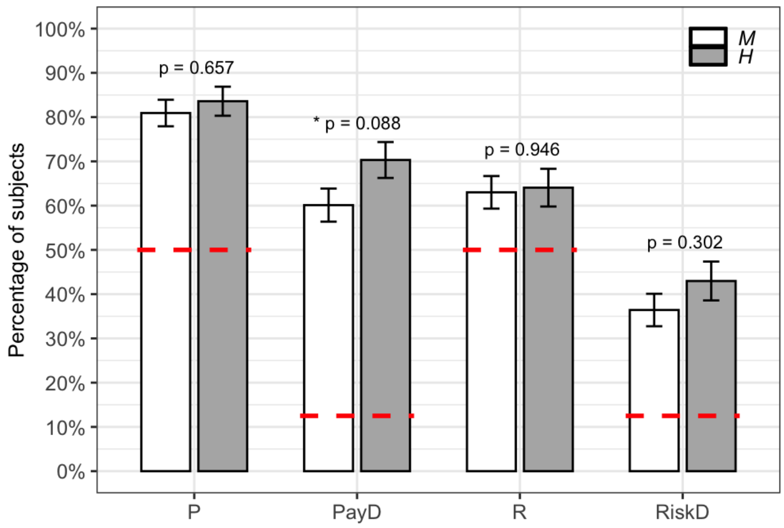

Figure 2: Study 2: Outcomes by incentive scheme. Error bars show ±1 standard error of the proportion for each bar.

4 Conclusion

We present two studies ($n = 242$ and $n = 301$) in which participants played two coordination games: one with a payoff-dominant and another with a risk-dominant equilibrium. Participants were randomly assigned to either a monetary or a hypothetical payment scheme.

We examined four outcomes: whether participants chose the payoff-dominant equilibrium, whether they selected the argument consistent with that choice, whether they chose the strategy leading to the risk-dominant equilibrium, and whether they selected the argument consistent with it. In none of these cases did we find any effect of the payment scheme on behavior. We therefore conclude that monetary incentives did not produce the expected effect. In other words, using hypothetical incentives did not reduce coordination rates.

However, we cannot conclude that incentives do not matter in any strategic environment; rather, our work provides an example where they appear to be irrelevant. This paper leaves two questions open: first, whether participants would react differently if the incentives were higher (see, for example, Enke et al., 2023). Although the high levels of coordination observed under both payment schemes suggest that participants took the task seriously, we do not know what would happen with higher stakes. Second, it seems that our instructions—very intuitive thanks to the use of colored buttons—may also have contributed to the high levels of coordination. We do not know whether less visual instructions would yield different results.

In any case, despite its limitations, our study—based on two well—powered samples—suggests that payments have no effect either on participants' decisions or on the arguments they used.

Data statement

The replication data and code for this article are openly available in Harvard Dataverse at https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/YTZRR6.

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A Additional analysis

Table A1: Balance check across studies.

	Monetary (M)	Hypothetical (H)	Difference (H-M)	p-value
Study 1				
age	18.62	18.55	-0.07	0.784
CRT	1.82	1.79	-0.03	0.756
ToM	6.49	6.67	0.18	0.238
female	0.57	0.57	0	0.987
university	0.47	0.41	-0.05	0.424
F joint test			0.52	0.758
Study 2				
age	19.45	19.66	0.21	0.237
CRT	2.03	2.16	0.13	0.223
ToM	6.69	6.73	0.04	0.776
female	0.42	0.41	-0.02	0.785
F-joint test			0.73	0.569

Note: p-values correspond to two-sided tests of equality of means. The F joint test evaluates the null hypothesis that all means are equal.

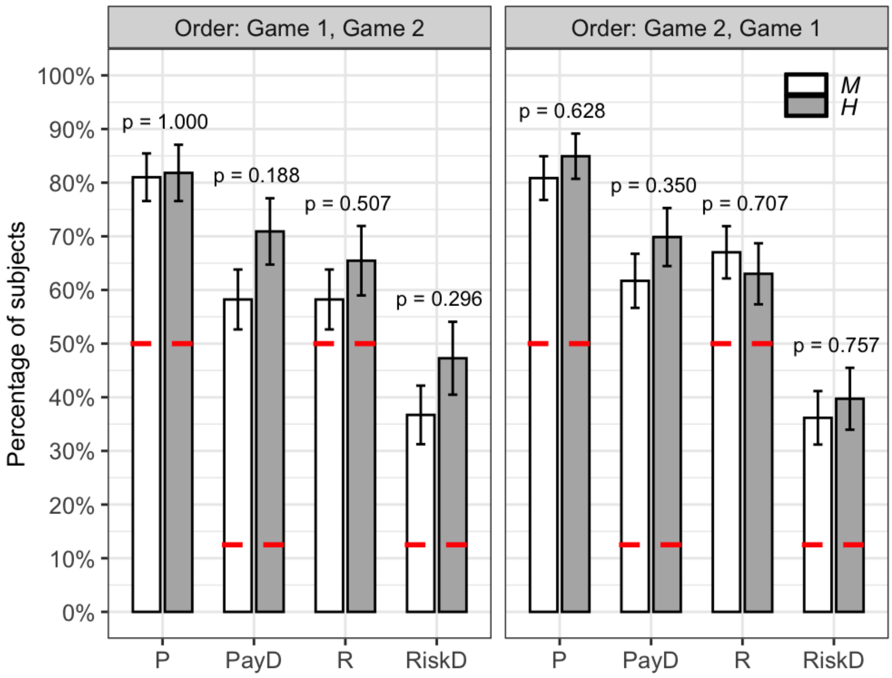

Figure A1: Study 2: Outcomes by incentive scheme and Game order

B Regression Analysis

Table A2: OLS estimation of the effect of *hypothetical* incentives on coordination (Study 1).

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	P	P	$PayD$	$PayD$	R	R	$RiskD$	$RiskD$
hypothetical	0.0575	0.0493	0.0293	0.0207	-0.0550	-0.0519	-0.0769	-0.0691
	(0.053)	(0.053)	(0.061)	(0.061)	(0.064)	(0.064)	(0.063)	(0.064)
	[0.277]	[0.350]	[0.633]	[0.735]	[0.392]	[0.421]	[0.227]	[0.280]
age		-0.0101		-0.0331		0.0247		-0.0103
		(0.027)		(0.033)		(0.025)		(0.031)
		[0.705]		[0.310]		[0.324]		[0.739]
CRT		0.0413		0.0651		-0.0651*		0.0376
		(0.034)		(0.039)		(0.039)		(0.039)
		[0.231]		[0.100]		[0.096]		[0.330]
female		0.0431		0.1115*		-0.0734		-0.1129*
		(0.056)		(0.065)		(0.069)		(0.068)
		[0.443]		[0.087]		[0.291]		[0.096]
Constant	0.7309***	0.8160*	0.6369***	1.0211*	0.4960***	0.2487	0.3521***	0.5402
	(0.072)	(0.450)	(0.080)	(0.554)	(0.083)	(0.447)	(0.079)	(0.547)
	[0.000]	[0.071]	[0.000]	[0.066]	[0.000]	[0.578]	[0.000]	[0.325]
Observations	242	240	242	240	241	240	241	240
R-squared	0.027	0.034	0.058	0.086	0.045	0.061	0.040	0.056
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Note: Estimation of the effect of *hypothetical* incentives on playing P and PayD (models 1–4), and on playing R and RiskD (models 5–8), using linear regressions. Model 1 estimates the effect of hypothetical on playing P; Model 2 adds baseline controls. The same structure is applied to the other dependent variables (PayD, R, and RiskD). All regressions include robust standard errors and session fixed effects. The controls included in the regression are age, CRT score, and gender (female). Two observations were dropped because two subjects did not complete the CRT. Robust standard errors are shown in parenthesis and p-values in brackets. Asterisks denote significance levels: *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.

Table A3: OLS estimation of the effect of *hypothetical* incentives on coordination controlling for order effects (Study 2).

VARIABLES	(1) P	(2) P	(3) P	(4) P	(5) $PayD$	(6) $PayD$	(7) $PayD$	(8) $PayD$	(9) R	(10) R	(11) R	(12) R	(13) $RiskD$	(14) $RiskD$	(15) $RiskD$	(16) $RiskD$
hypothetical (H)	0.0137	0.0063	0.0244	0.0086	0.0825	0.0736	0.0665	0.0492	-0.0143	-0.0218	-0.0726	-0.0842	0.0368	0.0255	0.0048	-0.0156
	(0.045)	(0.045)	(0.060)	(0.060)	(0.055)	(0.056)	(0.075)	(0.076)	(0.056)	(0.056)	(0.074)	(0.075)	(0.057)	(0.056)	(0.076)	(0.076)
	[0.760]	[0.889]	[0.683]	[0.886]	[0.138]	[0.186]	[0.375]	[0.516]	[0.800]	[0.698]	[0.329]	[0.262]	[0.521]	[0.652]	[0.950]	[0.837]
$game1first$ ($G1$)	-0.0117	0.0092	-0.0014	0.0114	-0.0259	-0.0059	-0.0413	-0.0289	-0.0636	-0.0463	-0.1197	-0.1051	0.0309	0.0592	0.0000	0.0205
	(0.047)	(0.047)	(0.062)	(0.061)	(0.056)	(0.056)	(0.074)	(0.074)	(0.057)	(0.057)	(0.075)	(0.076)	(0.056)	(0.056)	(0.072)	(0.071)
	[0.804]	[0.845]	[0.981]	[0.852]	[0.643]	[0.917]	[0.575]	[0.696]	[0.263]	[0.417]	[0.113]	[0.166]	[0.585]	[0.291]	[1.000]	[0.774]
$H * G1$			-0.0243	-0.0053			0.0364	0.0553			0.1330	0.1414			0.0731	0.0930
			(0.092)	(0.092)			(0.110)	(0.111)			(0.112)	(0.112)			(0.113)	(0.111)
			[0.792]	[0.954]			[0.741]	[0.618]			[0.238]	[0.210]			[0.518]	[0.403]
age		0.0064		0.0064		-0.0264		-0.0267		-0.0145		-0.0154		-0.0111		-0.0116
		(0.020)		(0.020)		(0.025)		(0.024)		(0.024)		(0.024)		(0.024)		(0.024)
		[0.745]		[0.744]		[0.284]		[0.276]		[0.553]		[0.524]		[0.651]		[0.633]
CRT		0.0572**		0.0572**		0.0638*		0.0637*		0.0746**		0.0745**		0.0998***		0.0997***
		(0.027)		(0.027)		(0.033)		(0.033)		(0.033)		(0.033)		(0.034)		(0.034)
		[0.037]		[0.037]		[0.053]		[0.054]		[0.025]		[0.025]		[0.003]		[0.003]
female		-0.0866*		-0.0862*		-0.0630		-0.0665		-0.0161		-0.0251		-0.0717		-0.0776
		(0.049)		(0.050)		(0.061)		(0.062)		(0.061)		(0.062)		(0.060)		(0.060)
		[0.081]		[0.086]		[0.306]		[0.287]		[0.792]		[0.683]		[0.233]		[0.198]
Constant	0.7143***	0.5163	0.7089***	0.5143	0.4776***	0.8667*	0.4856***	0.8879*	0.7522***	0.8650*	0.7815***	0.9190*	0.2902***	0.3140	0.3063***	0.3496
	(0.096)	(0.385)	(0.098)	(0.386)	(0.102)	(0.483)	(0.105)	(0.483)	(0.099)	(0.484)	(0.105)	(0.483)	(0.094)	(0.479)	(0.097)	(0.479)
	[0.000]	[0.181]	[0.000]	[0.184]	[0.000]	[0.074]	[0.000]	[0.067]	[0.000]	[0.075]	[0.000]	[0.058]	[0.002]	[0.513]	[0.002]	[0.466]
Observations	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301	301
R-squared	0.040	0.068	0.040	0.068	0.083	0.104	0.084	0.105	0.062	0.081	0.067	0.086	0.082	0.118	0.083	0.120
Session FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Note: Estimation of the effect of *hypothetical* incentives on playing P and PayD (models 1–8), and on playing R and RiskD (models 9–16), using linear regressions. Model 1 estimates the effect of hypothetical on playing P controlling for order of the game; Model 2 adds baseline controls, Model 3 includes the interaction between order and the hypothetical treatment, while Model 4 is the same specification of model 3 but adds additional controls. The same structure is applied to the other dependent variables (PayD, R, and RiskD). All regressions include robust standard errors and session fixed effects. The controls included in the regression are age, CRT score, and gender (female). Robust standard errors are shown in parenthesis and p-values in brackets. Asterisks denote significance levels: *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.